

Chapter III

Humanitarian and special economic assistance

In 1997, the United Nations, through the Department of Humanitarian Affairs (DHA), continued to engage in a broad spectrum of relief operations to provide humanitarian and special economic assistance to States and population groups stricken by war, internal strife and environmental disasters. Consolidated inter-agency appeals in 1997 were ongoing in or launched for Afghanistan, Albania, Angola, Chechnya in the Russian Federation, the Democratic People's Republic of Korea, countries of the Great Lakes region of Africa, Liberia, Sierra Leone, Somalia, the Sudan, Tajikistan and the territories of the former Yugoslavia.

During the year, DHA helped 46 Member States in coping with 66 natural disasters and environmental emergencies.

Humanitarian assistance

Strengthening coordination

Reports of Secretary-General. In response to Economic and Social Council resolution 1995/56 [YUN 1995, p. 927], the Secretary-General submitted, in July, an interim report [E/1997/98] containing a review of the capacity of the UN humanitarian system to respond to complex crises and disasters.

With regard to the framework through which the United Nations responded to humanitarian crises, the Secretary-General stated that the governing bodies of the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR), the World Food Programme (WFP), the United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF), the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), the World Health Organization (WHO) and the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO) had adopted recommendations to strengthen their organizational capacity, as well as to encourage cooperation with the United Nations Department of Humanitarian Affairs (DHA) and other organizations to ensure a coherent system-wide approach to humanitarian assistance. DHA supported the Emergency Relief Coordinator (ERC) in discharging coordination responsibilities for complex emergencies and

natural disasters. The Inter-Agency Standing Committee (IASC), whose members were the heads or designated representatives of the UN humanitarian organizations—FAO, UNDP, UNHCR, UNICEF, WFP, WHO—had reviewed systemic issues in order to develop a more strategic system-wide approach to humanitarian assistance that would enable IASC members to respond better to crises but would also focus on capacity-building and enhance support with recovery and rehabilitation activities. The volatile nature of current conflicts and resulting threats to regional peace and security had brought about an increased role for the Security Council. Non-governmental organizations (NGOs), whose fieldworkers were implementing partners with UN organizations, were an integral part of humanitarian assistance activities.

Regarding the capacity of the United Nations to respond to complex crises, the DHA Humanitarian Early Warning System (HEWS) had improved the information processes serving the system but the early warning capacity could be strengthened further. The Secretary-General proposed that inter-agency consultations on early warning be resumed and the conclusions fed into the IASC process to facilitate contingency planning and preparedness. There was also a critical need to develop a common inter-agency method for contingency planning to provide a basis of common planning parameters. UN agencies in the field had generally developed adequate capacity to rapidly deploy staff and relief and logistical support materials. However, within the UN Secretariat, most rules and procedures were not conducive to rapid response. Thus, more flexible procedures should be pursued. Inadequate funding remained an important constraint to the development of contingency planning and implementation of situation-specific preparedness measures.

With regard to information collection, analysis and dissemination, DHA had formed the Integrated Regional Information Network (IRIN) to manage an up-to-date flow of information to and from humanitarian participants engaged in the Great Lakes region of Africa. An IRIN/West Africa was in the process of being established. DHA also had developed Reliefweb, which consolidated and organized information on current humanitarian emergencies and natural disasters and made it immediately available on the Inter-